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Let's Do Away with Rural

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Abstract — Research on rural areas has tended to adopt a theoretically undifferentiated approach to what is 'rural'. Differences across rural areas have been recognized, but they have been inadequately theorized and similarities in causal processes across the rural–urban divide have received far too little attention. This paper argues that the complexity of structure-agency interrelationships is little understood, so that theoretical advancement is perhaps better approached by simplifying research designs by evaluating the circumstances under which similar structural contexts are associated with both similar and dissimilar behavioural outcomes. It is argued that if this approach is taken rural locations will need to be differentiated on account of their very different structural circumstances, while rural and urban places will often belong to the same population for the purposes of theoretical sampling.

Introduction

The principal argument of this paper is that there is too much laxity in the treatment of rural areas in empirical analysis. Too often, based on their supposed rural attributes, researchers have assumed that places are equivalent to one another when they are dominated by very different causal processes. Let me be clear; I am not calling for the abandonment of the word 'rural' in everyday expression. Neither am I calling for a reorganization of the institutional structures within which research is undertaken (which presupposes that some researchers have to undertake 'rural' research as their institutions are so named). Whether or not I believe these steps are desirable is immaterial to my argument. The central point is that the undifferentiated use of 'rural' in a research context is detrimental to the advancement of social theory. As such, it is critical that notions of rurality do not guide the selection of sites for empirical investigation. The broad category 'rural' is obfuscatory, whether the aim is description or theoretical evaluation, since intra-rural differences can be enormous and rural–urban similarities can be sharp.

At the local level, causal processes draw sustenance from local social structures (as expressed in basic, longer-term attributes of capital accumulation, the state and civil society), with behavioural outcomes being contingent upon the interrelations of structural conditions and on the manner and circumstances under which these are transposed through human agency into behaviour (e.g. Pfeffer, 1983). Critical to theorizing human activity, therefore, is understanding interrelationships between social structures and the mechanisms through which structures are translated into action (and the autonomy human agency has from structural forces). Since, in effect, structures are simply social processes that have attained some measure of permanency (whether through little-questioned acceptability or a sense of the inevitable or unchangeable), the crucial theoretical issues can be narrowed down to four issues: understanding how and why 'permanency' in social relationships is attained; understanding the compromises reached between seemingly permanent social relationships in different arenas of activity (viz. how do established practices of capital accumulation alter fundamental relationships of civil society and the state, etc.); understanding how and why seemingly permanent social relationships are reproduced over time (viz. how do established practices of capital accumulation draw on and help sustain fundamental relationships of civil society and the state, etc.); and, understanding the variability of behaviour within established practices and how these can mould established relationships. These four issues are equally significant and all merit empirical investigation. But from what point should we embark on such investigations, given the interconnections that exist between these issues? Here our theoretical perspective should provide the guiding light. In effect, '. . . in conducting explanation we should construct abstractions appropriate to the causal chain under investigation, including spatial specification if and when relevant' (Duncan and Savage, 1989, p. 203). The essential argument of this

paper is that the designation 'rural', no matter how defined, does not provide an appropriate abstraction.

Why do I feel that a paper of this kind is necessary? After all, it is more than 20 years since Pahl (1966) sank a wooden stave deep into the heart of the phantom that afforded rural areas peculiar causal properties. As Newby (1986, p. 209) expressed it: 'There is now, surely, a general awareness that what constitutes 'rural' is wholly a matter of convenience and that arid and abstract definitional exercises are of little utility'. The general thrust of this view I endorse. But I do not accept the particulars of Newby's seemingly widely accepted view. Embodied within his statement is a sentiment I must reject. To me, if we cannot agree what 'rural' is, this does not give us *carte blanche* to rely on 'convenient' definitions of it. Rather, it behoves us to abandon the category 'rural' as an analytical construct. Failure to do so is like putting together a football team whose players are drawn from Australian rules, gridiron, rugby and soccer, and not telling any of them which set of rules apply on the field. I believe that if we are to understand the jumble of seemingly incomprehensible actions of the players we are interested in, we should take our eyes off the playing field and start interpreting the rules of engagement.

Frameworks for rural inquiries

Within all social science disciplines there are geographically-based sub-fields. Those who wish to object that economics possesses a sub-discipline of agricultural, not rural, economics, and that there is no distinctive rural sub-field within political science, should hold their breath and reconsider. For one thing, both disciplines have sub-fields with explicit urban titles, which signifies that rural and urban are held to be distinctive. For another, agricultural economics journals regularly include articles on housing, recreation and manufacturing (to name but a few); the sub-discipline includes the word agricultural but its practitioners do not restrict their work to agriculture. Even the psychologists have been taken in, ensuring that the library shelves have volumes on 'rural psychology' (e.g. Childs and Melton, 1983). Yet the mere existence of a geographically-based sub-field does not have to carry the weighty overtone of causal specificity. The designation 'rural' is for many researchers merely a symbol of interest in small settlements or in particular kinds of economic activity; it is not a statement about unique causal properties. Perhaps for such researchers it is relevant to draw a distinction between 'rural', meaning a particular kind of geographical milieu, and 'rurality', which refers to a particular behaviour style associated with such areas. Yet both these concepts are problematical. Like community and locality, few agree on what either term means (Hillery, 1955; Duncan, 1989) and their usage implies a uniformity of condition that is not present. Beside which, many studies which proclaim their rural concerns are inappropriately designated. Rather than being concerned with 'rural issues', they in fact focus upon (say) problems of providing services to small dispersed populations (a problem equally important for those investigating city services for individuals with specific physical handicaps or special medical needs) or the diffusion of product innovations amongst small business operations (in this case farms, but equally applicable for other types of family-based firms).

In effect, rural researchers have been focusing their attention on the outfield, with too little appreciation that the same rules of engagement apply in the penalty box. To understand the game itself, we need to understand both and, vitally, also appreciate the abstract rules which direct and constrain activities on the field as a whole. Fortunately, there has been growing recognition of the need to understand the rules of the game (see Cloke, 1989). However, little has been done so far to tie this awareness in with actual behaviour. The time is ripe, therefore, for a word of warning, which is that before we embark on a new round of 'informed' investigative endeavours we should be sure that our efforts start from a theoretically valid foundation. We might assume that we know what the pitch looks like, but this will not get us far in understanding events if we continue to assume that the one standing close to the goals is a centre-forward when that player puts most effort into attempting a drop-goal. Put simply, let us not let our new awareness come unstuck in the inertia of our investigative approaches. We have to understand the rules of the game before we can understand the movement of the ball, but we also need to appreciate that just because we believe the players are occupying the same field of play does not mean that they hold to this view. Although rarely, if ever, expressed explicitly, in so far as investigators have delineated their study sites by their 'rural' attributes, they have assumed a similarity of causal processes across locations (to extend the football analogy, the effectiveness of players is assumed to be decided by the qualities of the players themselves, rather than by dissimilar interpretations of the rules). This is a fundamental error. Directing attention to rural areas as a whole (even if only by implication) is obfuscatory because divisions within and between locations in the rural realm are critical.

Distinguishing rural areas

The last comment might seem naïve in that researchers have recognized that rural areas are

differentiated (e.g. Webber and Craig, 1978; Cloke and Edwards, 1986). However, the point is pertinent on account of the manner in which researchers have treated such distinctions. Capstick *et al.* (1986, p. 3) illustrate the tendency when noting that:

> The author's [sic] view is that the separate treatment of rural areas is still valid since they all share to some extent a number of characteristics normally missing or poorly developed in towns and cities.

In effect, 'we recognize that there is differentiation, but 'for convenience' we are going to ignore it'. This does not mean that inter-local dissimilarities are not acknowledged, but that they are ignored because certain threads bind all rural locations. Two research projects which suggest that this is the case are those by Chapman (1986) and by Camasso and Moore (1985). In Scotland, Chapman found that even after allowing for dissimilarities in social class, migration history and occupational prospects, social mobility in peripheral areas was lower than in the urban core (see also Hanson, 1982). Camasso and Moore (1985) likewise recorded that rural–urban differences persisted in attitudes to social welfare held by Pennsylvania residents, even after taking account of age, sex and educational differences. But what does 'rural' mean in these instances? Since the designation 'rural' is a matter of convenience, how can we justify using it as a causal category? After all, the word 'rural' can mean very different things. As Sher (1977, p. 1) commented:

> The simple fact is that rural people, rural communities, and rural conditions are so diverse that we can find evidence to support nearly any characterization. Someone wishing to describe rural America [sic] as a collection of Lilliputs or as bastions of racism, cultural and economic stagnation, reactionary politics, and stifling social environments will not have a difficult time finding rural communities that substantiate this negative analysis. However, another person desirous of portraying rural America as a network of stable, efficient, thriving communities, or as the nation's best example of social egalitarianism, economic independence, cultural continuity, participatory democracy, and institutional accountability will have equal ease in justifying this favorable characterization.

There is little point bundling together places of such diversity into one 'convenient' category if in doing so we obscure causality. Social mobility in one 'rural' area might well be lowered by occupational factors, but in another lack of opportunities consequent upon small settlement size might be crucial (or even the value disposition of local elites). The fact that both Camasso and Moore (1985) and Chapman (1986) placed their primary causal emphasis on socio-economic discrimination, using rurality simply as a secondary element in their analyses, in no way absolves them from the charge of relying on a chaotic concept in their analysis (Urry, 1984). It is moreover a concept whose character is little agreed with even by those who have long lived in rural areas (Matthews, 1988).

Yet many researchers refer to rural places as if they possess a unitary character, with widespread agreement on both their attributes and their areal delination. Thus, Blunden and Curry (1985, p. 192) report that rural areas receive less than their fair share of public expenditure compared to urban centres, and illustrate this by providing local government expenditure figures for rural and urban England in 1981/2. This should strike any reader as peculiar, given that local government in England only distinguishes between rural and urban in the sense of separating out the seven largest metropolitan cities. Perhaps, as a loose descriptive vehicle, there is merit in acknowledging a distinction between rural and urban. However, what starts as loose description too readily attains causal status:

> . . . it seems naïve to assume that simply by crossing an administrative or census defined boundary an individual is conveniently transformed from an 'urban' to a 'rural' person. Yet, not withstanding the literature on the adjustment of rural to urban migrants, this is what some theorists have implied (Rowles, 1988, p. 116).

What is more there is a danger that by providing a 'landscape' focus to analyzing problems, real causal forces will be disguised. Thus, when the Highland and Islands Development Board identified housing problems in rural areas as retarding the growth of economic enterprises (Shucksmith, 1987), it was not identifying a rural condition at all, but one that is equally evident in inner cities (e.g. Cullingford and Openshaw, 1982).

The point is not that rural areas (however defined) are an illegitimate focus of research attention, but that it is not theoretically valid to group them together in an undifferentiated manner. Let us consider this point with regard to selecting places within which to investigate particular social processes (class conflict, patriarchy, pressure group politics or whatever). If we reject the deterministic assumption that social structures are translated directly into behaviour, then, given our limited knowledge of relationships between structure and agency, understanding could be deepened by exploring theoretical propositions in relatively constrained environments. Assume we are concerned with understanding differences in behaviour across places. This being so, a valid way of proceeding would be to identify places for intensive investigation which *a priori* can be *assumed* to be dominated by similar causal forces (the key word is

assumed, since whether or not this is actually the case is a matter for empirical verification). Rather than grouping places by settlement size or occupation, on the assumption that, while different, they come from the same rural 'population' (e.g. Bradley 1986), the two most obvious criteria for selecting places would either be similarity in behaviour or shared, theoretically significant, socio-economic structures. In either case, theoretical propositions can be probed, either by evaluating whether similar outcomes emerge from equivalent causal forces or by assessing how shared structures are transposed into (similar or dissimilar) behaviour forms. For rural areas to qualify as a credible category for the selection of such research sites, two equally important conditions would have to be met. First, it would have to be demonstrated that causally important forces are organized, or generated if you like, at a local level. Second, it would have to be demonstrated that these forces are distinctive in rural and urban environments. Put simply, the designation rural would have to identify locations with distinctive causal forces. If these specifications are met, then genuinely local, distinctively rural causal forces can be said to exist.

Local causal effects

The question of whether genuine local causal effects can be identified has recently exercised the minds of many social researchers. Couched in the context of so-called locality studies, the importance of local causal effects has proved to be difficult to establish (partly because there is little agreement on the meaning of 'locality'; Gregson, 1987; Duncan, 1989). Yet, within the literature, many researchers have emphasized the importance of *local* causal forces. Illustrative of this tendency is the assertion of Cohen (1982, p. 7) that: 'Locality is an anathema to the logic of the modern political economy and, perhaps for precisely that reason, is increasingly vocal in almost all spheres of contemporary life.' The importance of this kind of claim comes from its message that the strength of local distinctiveness arises from local actions. This is a different point from that made by Urry (1981), who suggested that regional economic structures were in decline as their employment base weakened (e.g. coal mining in north-east England), so inter-local differences will probably become more notable. It also raises peculiar question marks against national attempts to emphasize local differences (as in the efforts of the Thatcher government to break national wage negotiations, so as to weaken labour and create more options for capital investment). As Vidich and Bensman (1958) pointed out, it is ironical that the self-imagery of professed 'ruralites' is a fabrication of an urban-based mass media. It would be even more ironical if we were to take nationally inspired local differentiations as a symbol of a new-found rural local causality.

Hence, there is the issue of how autonomous local causal processes arise from 'outside' events. I would not accept the point which Duncan (1989) seems to make, namely that the notion of local causal forces is inappropriate because locally autonomous social units rarely exist, for this charge applies equally to the concepts economic, geographical, political, psychological and social. If we employ concepts only when they refer to the 'pure' form of a 'substance' then we will be in a sorry state indeed, for we will have effectively eliminated 99% of our subject matter and left ourselves merely with trivia to investigate. Readers might point out that if we allow 'impurity' in our concepts, why not accept 'rural' as a valid, if 'impure', analytical category. The main reason can be explained in an analogy. Arguing that rural–urban differences are not causal, but that dissimilarities in 'rural' and 'urban' circumstances are sufficiently important for this divide to be analytically valid, is much like insisting that it is valid to distinguish people by their height because male–female differences are real, and one dimension to male–female differentiation is height. In fact, this analogy is not wholly appropriate, for at present we are insufficiently aware of what the rural–urban divide is a proxy for; researchers are investigating the values, activity patterns and appearance of (say) short people (rural areas?), with only a passing reference (if that) to the role of gender. Thus, when Thrift (1987) informed us that he wants to see the urban–rural shift in industry described in terms of class relations, this contrasts starkly with the prevalence of undifferentiated references to 'rural industrialization' in much of the literature; even when authors insist that rural areas are not all the same (e.g. Healey and Ilbery, 1985). Thrift's framework urges us to assess whether players are constrained by different rules and whether the same rules direct those who occupy positions outside what, for 'convenience', has been delineated as the playing field. The 'rural industrialization' approach, by contrast, restricts its insight largely to following the movement of the ball and identifying its shape. Ultimately, this means that the regulations under which the ball is received, and consequently the receiving player's options on gaining it, are little understood.

The fundamental difference between these perspectives arises both because Thrift specifies a causal nexus (class relations) as the issue of primary importance and because his emphasis on causal mechanisms directs attention to the question of local

autonomy. This is a concept to which rural investigators have devoted insufficient attention (as have their urban counterparts). It is also a concept that challenges any notion of uniformity across rural areas. Take, for example, the question of how the absentee-ownership of local enterprises affects broader community questions. Even with no change in the socio-economic circumstances of a settlement, we know that a decline in local ownership in favour of absentee-ownership poses more of a threat to employment stability (Anderson and Barkley, 1982), as well as broadening the base of local power structures, thus pushing elitist power networks in a more pluralist direction (Schulze, 1958; French, 1970). Hence, with no change in either basic socio-economic circumstances or landscape features, the *modus vivendi* of social relationships can alter significantly, with places that were once little different emerging as dissimilar entities. That none of this is new makes the literature on locality studies look somewhat amateurish. In particular, there is a long history of researchers identifying dissimilar extra-local linkages amongst social groups in single places. Bennett's (1967, 1969) work on rural Saskatchewan is pertinent here, most especially for the differences in rancher and cattle–grain farmer interactions with non-local institutions. At a more theoretical level, Warren (1963) emphasized long ago that social relations in places can be distinguished by the character and strength of their horizontal (intra-local) and vertical (extra-local) linkages, a point that is implicit in Cox and Mair's (1988) commentary on how locations are differentiated by the strength of local attachment amongst capitalists and within civil society. Such distinctions are extremely important, for only if a territorial unit retains or acquires significance for its residents can *local* causal forces be assumed to be a force to be reckoned with (Kesselman and Rosenthal, 1972).

Many rural researchers think of local social relationships as being mediated through fundamental structures like kinship, friendship, neighbourhood and sect (Cohen, 1982), but it is also necessary to draw attention to 'external' forces as instigators of local sentiments and attachments. Not simply are individual acts of 'neighbourliness' commonly insufficient to explain the appearance of distinct local traits, but it is also true that local identities can be an outcome of external forces (Crenson, 1983); this is seen when a community identity is forged around (say) opposition to higher-tier governmental decisions about local facilities (e.g. Wild, 1983). What is more, it could well be that the very framework around which local attachments centre is externally derived (as in British local government structures being decided by national government; see Hoggart, in press). As reviews of the concept local autonomy make clear, local–extra-local relationships are extremely complex, varying across local areas and social groups, by issue, with precise structural arrangements and within decision-making processes (Clark, 1974; Hoggart, 1981; Clark, 1984). Empirically there is a great deal to be done. But what can be stated is that a focus on rural areas *per se* would be a distraction, for it would smooth over the complexity of local–extra-local interchanges with an aura of intra-rural similarity.

Distinctions of rural and urban

A central argument of this paper is that causal forces are not distinctive in rural areas, nor are they uniform in them. The latter of these points is well recognized, for researchers commonly select a variety of rural locations for their investigations (e.g. Bradley, 1986). However, in so far as the population from which these research sites are selected is defined simply by settlement size or position along a supposed rural–urban continuum, all that is happening is that players are being grouped together because their shirts are the same colour, with no questions asked about the game they are playing. This criticism applies even when 'rural' is distinguished in complex ways. Take, for example, Cloke's index of rurality that is based on the multivariate analysis of multiple socio-economic indicators (Cloke, 1977; Cloke and Edwards, 1986) or the demarcation of daily urban systems as a means of specifying rural areas (e.g. Coombes *et al.*, 1981). Despite the care taken over such typologies, these categorizations do not distinguish places in which distinctive social processes are operating. At one level this can be seen in the manner in which these schemes rely on unitary conceptions of geographical differentiation. They use a variety of indicators for the precise delineation of places but their central classificatory message is the rural–urban continuum (Cloke) or the number of people commuting to urban centres (Coombes *et al.*) In truth, rural areas are distinguishable from one another along a variety of dimensions. These are not captured in simplistic notions like the rural–urban continuum or the urban field.

Even if we focus solely on linkages between urban and rural areas, there are significant complexities in inter-settlement interactions that are not addressed in notions of a rural–urban continuum or an urban field. Thorpe (1972) brings this point home with force. The crux of Thorpe's commentary is the character of links between settlements. The crucial point is that settlements are integrated with others in a variety of ways, so forces impacting on neighbouring places can be dissimilar. Consistent with the logic

of rural–urban continuum schemes is the idea that central place systems tie settlements together (viz. linkages between one settlement and others are distinguished by a hierarchy); hence the strongest ties are local (between proximate places in the urban hierarchy), with weaker connections further up the hierarchy. The urban field schema places emphasis elsewhere, by proposing that major ties are associated with settlements toward the top of the urban hierarchy. Linkages between local centres are proposed to have been weakened by the pull of major urban cores, with places peripheral to large centres having faint urban ties and a confused and parochial complex of inter-settlement linkages. In terms of conceptualizing which areas are rural, the city-centred vision of the urban field specification leads to fewer places being in the residual rural category, compared to numbers in rural–urban continuum formulations. As a consequence, the geographical distinctions derived from these schemes are different. Yet the schemes themselves are similar in so far as they assume that household linkage patterns and, directly or indirectly, the socio-economic attributes of householders/workers, are central elements in distinguishing between settlement types. They also assume that locationally specific causal forces allow places to be ordered on one dimension.

In Thorpe's (1972) encampments he offered an alternative vision; one in which networks of control act as the glue binding locations together. Encampments are settlements that have relatively few ties (of certain, but by no means all, types) with other local centres and are weakly integrated into a nearby urban field, but which have strong links with (possibly distant) places from which forces that dominate their future emanate. Almost any export-oriented activity could provide a base for such an arrangement, with tourism as one example (illustrations of encampments abound in the volume of Aceves and Douglass, 1976). If you want to understand certain social processes in these places, it is little use looking at their standing in commuter belts or on a rural–urban continuum. It is to their organizing centre that attention must be directed (as evinced in the impact of funds from the U.S.A. on social change in Irish rural settlements (e.g. Brody, 1973). Indeed, as Hill (1987) noted for the company towns based on the automobile industry, the organizational principles which lie behind events in such places can effectively bypass the national arena to find their expression on a world stage.

In what could be seen as a special variation on the encampment theme, Thorpe (1972) also identified 'industrial zones'. Here he was concerned with how the fortunes of one area are tied to a series of others because they are an integrated economic system, often because their economic base is controlled by a single company which orchestrates the functions of each settlement. An obvious example is where locally dominant enterprises are linked through vertical integration. A more topical situation, albeit with linkage patterns that are more changeable, as well as looser, exists in the banking realm. Trace the consequences of (say) Brazil or Mexico defaulting on their foreign debts and you first create trauma for the major banks in the U.S.A. and the U.K. (the largest nine U.S. banks have recently had 85% of their equity exposed in these two countries alone; Lowenthal, 1983). However, these banks lay-off their total loans, drawing funds from smaller institutions in order to lower their own risk, as well as enabling them to accumulate the sums required for large foreign loans (over 1000 banks have a stake in Mexico's debt; Holley, 1987). Evidence already suggests that rural banks are active participants in funnelling funds to larger institutions, as large city projects and international loans hold the prospect of greater yields than farm loans (Shane, 1971). A consequence is that the mechanisms through which significant change can be introduced into small-town U.S.A. have the potential of originating directly in Mexico City. The formality of overt, legal ownership might be missing between the residents of Hills, Iowa and the Mexican government, but, in practical terms, Mexican decisions can be as potent as those from direct legal contracts (between 1942 and 1980, 262 U.S.A. banks failed, but from 1980 to 1986 the number was over 400, with numerous farm households suffering hardship as a consequence; Smith, 1983; Kolko, 1988).

Thorpe's (1972) schema reveals that causal forces bind settlements in ways that are not apparent in the occupational, geographical or broader socio-economic structures of places. What is more, there is no reason why settlement systems do not overlap. Employees in manufacturing in rural settlements in Wisconsin might well find their employment prospects influenced by being in the urban field of Milwaukee, at the same time as their neighbour farmers are more strongly attached to (governmental and private sector) encampments with centres in Washington D.C. and Mexico City (respectively); albeit, for some farmers, ties through contracting or outright ownership could make their economic fortunes more dependent upon an industrial zone controlled by a vertically integrated combine. What is more, embedded within the social practices of the same settlement could be a network of social arrangements, indeed the main thrust of civil society, which carries a decidedly localist aura; places oriented towards a city for work can have different orientations for other activities (e.g. Pahl, 1965). Hence, places in a 'population' for one aspect

of social life might be aligned with a quite different population for another.

Specifying populations of research sites

That a particular place might be conceptualized as belonging to dissimilar populations depending upon the research question at hand signifies that reliance on uni-dimensional classifications for research site selection is inappropriate. This means that behaviour patterns in places with seemingly similar socio-economic foundations might be dissimilar, just as behavioural consistency might exist in places of seemingly slight compatibility. For our purposes, this point is made clear in evidence that there is consistency in socio-economic structures across the rural–urban divide (e.g. Cullingford and Openshaw, 1982), just as similar social behaviour was identified in both environments long ago (e.g. Williams, 1956; Young and Willmott, 1957; Vidich and Bensman, 1958; Gans, 1962). I do not mean by this that there are no differences between (most) rural and urban places, but rather that in the main these are generated by the uneven presence of some known causal factor '*X*', as opposed to either rurality or urbanity. The obvious follow-up point is that for theory to progress we should focus on '*X*' (and so select sites for intensive investigation based on its variable occurrence).

Of course, what we must also bear in mind is that social structure does not determine human action. Particular socio-economic forms, such as social homogeneity, might well favour one activity compared to another, but it cannot determine that one path is followed. Thus, despite the supposed conservatism of small places and agriculturalists, political radicalism has had a noteworthy presence in rural places in the U.S.A. (e.g. Shover, 1965; Burbank, 1971). As seen in the failure of such movements, social practices are crucially influenced by the ability (or inability) of persons to draw on the opportunities afforded by structural environments, as well as by their ability to overcome its constraints (e.g. through quality local leadership). Macintyre (1980, p. 184) noted the same when he found that the places which were labelled 'Little Moscows' in inter-war Britain were not distinguished by occupational structure — instrumental though this was in forging a spirit of solidarity that assisted collective action — but in the existence of '. . . a relatively small number of committed militants who were able to reach out to the bulk of the working-class inhabitants at particular moments of crisis'. In terms of the local presence or absence of radicalism, occupational homogeneity was a help, but so too was a sense of morality which pervaded these settlements (Macintyre, 1980). Indeed, if Rose (1989) is correct in her interpretation of Poplar in the 1920s, then 'economic explanations' which emphasize the occupational and trade union base of political radicalism should be downgraded, with more attention given to religion and neighbourliness. The uneven militancy of workers during the 1984–1985 British miners' strike further confirms that labour market conditions can be poor predictors of inter-local variability in social action (Rees, 1986).

For theoretical advancement, this confirms that detailed investigations are required to establish how social structures are transposed into particular activities. Yet since social structures provide the foundation stones on which precise behaviour patterns are built, when identifying places in which similar causal processes are expected to operate, an appropriate discriminator is the similarity of (theoretically significant) socio-economic conditions. Focusing on the three fundamental arenas of capital accumulation, the state and civil society, the remainder of this paper will examine how rural and urban environments share rather more causally significant structural conditions than has often been taken to be the case. With each of these arenas of social life embodying enormous variety and complexity, the sections below will simply draw out themes rather than attempting comprehensive argument. Yet for each, rural–urban similarities are not the sole fact to grasp. Also critical are divisions within the rural realm. These divisions are of a scale sufficient that it is inappropriate to assume that rural areas constitute a population which carries analytical value.

Capital accumulation

With regard to capital–labour relationships, what makes many rural areas unusual is not that they are dominated by agriculture, but that agriculture has a particular capital–labour interchange; this interchange is characterized by farmers being price-takers and by their necessity to operate in a competitive market economy (Hoggart, 1988). As such, agriculture is no different from many other arenas of economic enterprise (tourism and retailing are obvious examples of the same). The operational *modus vivendi* they share is quite different from that of so-called monopoly sectors, such as electronics and electrical engineering, in which companies have more control over the prices at which their products are sold (O'Connor, 1973; Offe, 1984). Certainly, there is a tendency for competitive sectors to be disproportionately represented in the employment structures of rural areas (just as the density of monopoly sector enterprises is greater in larger

centres). However, enterprises from both sector types are found in the rural and the urban realms. Consequently, a large farm element in the population provides insufficient grounds to distinguish class relations in rural places from those in (many) urban centres (e.g. resort towns). Not for one minute does this mean there are no differences between agriculture and other competitive market sectors. Most significantly, competitive market sectors are distinguished by the ability of their entrepreneurs to win 'protection' from the vagaries of true competition (O'Connor, 1973; Offe, 1984). In this regard, agriculture stands apart from retailing or tourism (to name two), since farmers have been more successful in lobbying state functionaries for protective measures (a fact that owes something to electoral clout, in some nations at least, which cannot be divorced from the efficacy of their organizational representatives, but which also owes much to the traditional power base and status of landowners). Yet, the protection afforded to farmers is not uniform; it varies from one farm product to another (and hence geographically).

Creating further divisions within the rural environment is the way the peculiar standing of agriculture can distinguish its operatives from those in other sectors. One symbol of this is seen in attitudinal differences between farmers and non-farmers in the countryside. As Glenn and Hill (1977) pointed out, much of the so-called disparity in rural–urban attitude differences has in reality been a farm–non-farm split, with farmers revealing the classic *petit bourgeois* inner conflict of siding with manual workers on most issues, but resembling business leaders and professionals on issues of labour–management conflict. Yet, over time, farm–non-farm differences appear to have eroded, as changes in the agricultural sector have bifurcated values (and social positions) within farming, and as off-farm work has become an increasingly important component of farmers' income. Although evidence on this score is not plentiful, it appears that class differences within agriculture might now be as important, or more important, than those between farmers and others (Coughenour and Christenson, 1983; Friedland and Pugliese, 1989). If this is broadly the case, there is little point lumping East Anglia and North Yorkshire together as similar rural areas (as in Webber and Craig, 1978), for the class structure of their agricultural endeavours are quite different (aptly illustrated when the Farmers' Union of Wales was formed in 1955 in reaction to the National Farmers' Union being dominated by English lowland farmers; Madgwick *et al.*, 1973).

From the market sector perspective of O'Connor (1973) and Offe (1984), areas which, based on theoretical expectation, should have communality in social class relations are those which are dominated by one of the following: competitive sectors, monopoly or state sectors (the latter is most apparent in the peculiar standing of Indian reserves, university towns and places dominated by military bases). Of course, not all places will be so dominated, for market segmentation is evident within labour markets as well as across them (Bradley, 1984). Yet it is still feasible to classify locations according to the economic power position of their particular combinations of market sectors (examples of such schemes include those by Urry, 1983; Hoggart, 1988). But as well as local market sector compositions, class relations will be influenced by the degree of local ownership of enterprises (Schulze, 1958; French, 1970). This latter factor points to an obvious problem with basing research site selection on expected similarities in causal processes, since while data availability for market sector analysis is not beyond the spectrum of compromise most social researchers are accustomed to (e.g. Bloomquist and Summers, 1982), the same cannot be said for place-specific information on who owns economic enterprises. Hence, as with so much social research, study site choice has to be made in the knowledge that the criterion of selection is not comprehensive. Indeed, absentee-ownership might in the end prove to be a more important causal force than market sector dominance. But this is a question for empirical investigation. At this point in time, the literature on rural areas contains too few studies drawing attention to either. However, by focusing on such factors it is possible to put causal paint on the canvas that forms part of a poorly explained rural picture. For one, income disparities in rural environments, the analysis of which can easily adopt a descriptive tone (e.g. Bradley, 1986), can take on a more theoretical orientation (Hoggart, 1987).

The state

The lack of a distinctive rural dimension to capital–labour relationships is compounded by the absence of a unique rural component to the state. Commentaries on rural areas have fallen too easily into the trap of assigning a 'conservative' tag to rural areas *per se*. Knoke and Henry (1977) dispel this vision by pointing to three main political practices in smaller settlements; radicalism (particularly agrarian), conservatism and mass apathy. There is no doubt that conservatism is the most widely acknowledged of these, but its existence needs to be linked to the societal and economic structures that pervade particular places. Reference has already been made to the *petit bourgeois* vision of many farmers. Undoubtedly, this has had an impact upon local state

institutions, for it has provided a solid voter stock which is opposed to higher taxes and favours self-help over governmental provision (both are not unexpected on a self-interest basis, given the competitive market situation of agriculture and the geographical isolation of farm homesteads, which makes farmers late beneficiaries from collective service provision). Adding impetus to tendencies toward inaction is pressure not to 'disrupt' the ongoing social calm by implementing innovative or potentially conflictual policies. This syndrome has been well exposed by Vidich and Bensman (1958), yet it behoves us to understand that there is nothing particularly rural about this phenomenon. Local government systems in the United States of America are dominated by small municipal institutions, both in cities and in the countryside (e.g. Hoggart, in press). As Greer and Greer (1976, p. 203) pointed out, even in cities, within such units:

> . . . it is clear that all the elaborate structure of popular democracy results in a government which is noncompetitive, often inactive, and unaccountable to the view of the people. This occurs because, paradoxically, the elected councils are so selfless that they 'couldn't care less' about remaining in office.

These words could have come straight from Vidich and Bensman (1958), for their account of rural politics is little different from this one. That size more than rurality is critical is well illustrated by the consequences of local government reorganization in England and Wales in 1974. After that time, non-partisanship declined significantly, larger organizations became the norm and electoral wards increased in size, all of which weakened associations between settlement type and political action (Grant, 1977). Thus, disparities in public service provision cannot be explained by reference to rurality. Rural councils might well be inadequate providers of public housing (Duncan, 1987), but this is no different from many city councils (e.g. Young and Kramer, 1978). As some comparative investigations have concluded, the key challenges for local public services are essentially the same in rural and urban areas (e.g. Grant, 1984).

What this means for the study of state institutions, like rural local government, is that we should not expect similarities in conditions within the rural realm, nor should we expect notable dissimilarities between rural and urban *per se*. Seroka (1986) offers one viewpoint on this by pointing to different policy practices amongst non-metropolitan counties in six U.S.A. states, drawing particular attention to the impact of population change and economic growth. Most probably, these policy divergences are reflections of the uneven presence of nationwide causal forces rather than expressions of local political 'cultures'. After all, population change is also an important force in distinguishing between policies in central cities (Dye, 1984), and economic circumstances have long been considered primary determinants of urban policy, even if evaluating their effects is problematical (Hoggart, 1989). This being so, when the intention is to explain behaviour in state institutions, there is little point selecting local authorities for analysis on the basis of their rural or urban character. Rather, places should be identified from expectations about shared causal structures. At one level these relate to the economic standing of institutions, but at another they are aligned with the power of electoral blocs, with both race (Dye and Renick, 1981) and gender relations (Duncan, forthcoming) providing obvious additions to more familiar expectations concerning the importance of long-term political party domination (Sharpe and Newton, 1984).

Civil society

Readers might object that settlement size itself distinguishes rural settlements from their urban counterparts. Most obviously, opportunity structures vary across these landscapes, as made evident in behavioural manifestations of civil society ranging from eye contact (Newman and McCauley, 1977), to sexual conduct (Ford and Bowie, 1989), to crime (Wilkinson, 1984) and on to social interaction (Bechtel, 1970). Yet, as McLaughlin (1986) warned, there are dangers in aligning such inequities in opportunity too closely with settlement type; both social deprivation and opportunity abundance affect people rather than places. Hence, as Pahl (1965, 1968, 1975) indicated long ago, within many settlements there is great variation in lifestyle. That those who share socio-economic circumstances and ways-of-life tend to engage in social interaction with those of similar standing in other settlements is significant, for it encourages the emergence of distinct groups within single settlements (Pahl, 1975; Harper, 1987). This merely reinforces the fact that a rural–urban divide is an inappropriate mechanism for distinguishing civil societies:

> Locality is a meaningful concept only in relation to the interests of individual people and not necessarily to groups of co-located people. The potential danger associated with locality studies is that, in their search for unique local social processes, researchers will reify the locality: it becomes abstracted from the more substantive concerns of recounting the structuration of people's lives in it and of investigating what is being done to those people. Place, as it were, in this manner takes priority over people (Jonas, 1988, pp. 106–107).

To me, this is precisely what happens when emphasis

is placed on the rural attributes of locations. Certainly, there are some good studies which have identified a strong place-specific orientation amongst residents of rural areas, but these orientations are specific to particular social groups, most especially those of lower income. We have long known that precisely the same groups are inclined to have strong place-specific traditions in cities (e.g. Young and Willmott, 1957; Gans, 1962).

The selection of rural sites for investigating civil society has commonly been approached from the perspective of similarity of social trends. Analyses of commuter villages and counterurbanization spring to mind for their attention to places which have experienced population growth. Dependent upon the precise objectives of the investigation and the causal origins of the selection criteria, such an approach to study site selection can have much to offer. The work of Perry *et al.* (1986) provides one illustration of this, for by focusing on reasons why people migrated into rejuvenated rural locations they were able to show how the same end-product results from different social processes. However, a frequent weakness in the evaluative framework of rural researchers is a failure to recognize that the same processes are at play in large cities. Perhaps if commuter villages had occupied a less exclusive position in the vision of rural investigators, it might have been recognized that similar processes were at work in the gentrification of inner-city neighbourhoods. That being recognized, we might have been less distracted by length of residence, and shown an earlier appreciation of the centrality of social class in local social conflicts (Cloke and Thrift, 1987). What I am saying, illustratively in the context of commuter villages and counterurbanization, is that what should have received more research attention is not the magnitude of population inflow, but the social character of that inflow. In other words, focus on the theoretically important, not simply on 'physical' appearance (hence, to understand the social significance of commuter villages, researchers would have been better served selecting and comparing places in which so-called 'local–newcomer' conflicts did and did not occur, rather than choosing population growth *per se* as the selection criterion).

Conclusion

In effect, what I have argued against in this paper is the pragmatic approach to study site selection. To me this is not helpful when searching for sites within which to conduct detailed analyses of social processes. My main objection to the pragmatic approach is simply that it groups together places in which social processes of a very different kind are in operation. However, could we circumvent this by including a number of places in our studies and conducting comparative analyses? I do not think so. Largely, this is because social processes within localities combine the particular and the general, agency and structure, the production of new forms of social life and the reproduction of existing forms, in differing, unknown quantities (and qualities). If we are to further the understanding of the complexity that exists, it seems to me that we would be better served to focus on particular social conditions (agency or structure) and evaluate how these unfold in particular settings. Over the recent past it has become abundantly clear that society and societal change are much more complex than our theoretical models have allowed for. Effectively, we are still searching for the basic building blocks to construct valid theoretical insight. If we accept this, then it seems logical to simplify our investigative endeavours so we can develop a firm grounding for our explanatory efforts. To me, we are currently equipped to learn addition, subtraction, division and multiplication, but simultaneous equations are a long way off. Yet society is expressed through simultaneous equations (and then some). If we can grasp addition, we might ultimately build towards simultaneous equations, but I do not fancy our chances if we throw ourselves at the algebra from the outset.

One aim behind our research should be to assess why similar structural conditions are associated with dissimilar behavioural orientations. In this way, we can assess the relevance and dimensions of contingent causal processes (and hopefully move towards developing theoretical perspectives which locate them within the framework of structural forces). At the same time, we need to expand our awareness of how similar behaviour outcomes are generated by dissimilar forces; in what ways and under what circumstances are structural forces diluted, distorted and demonstrated in particular social settings? In a nutshell, it is justified to select sites for detailed analysis on the basis of theoretical expectations about the similarity of dominant causal forces, for in this way the potency of these forces in different settings can be assessed. Places could also be selected on account of their similarity in behaviour patterns, as this provides us with a means of evaluating equivalency in the mechanisms which produce the same end-product. All this assumes that the criterion or criteria on which places are selected is theoretically derived (i.e. do not select on the basis of population growth if the aim is to study social conflict, use variables that differentiate between conflicting social groups) and we do not impose artificial barriers to our analysis such as rural–urban distinctions. What all this means is that

no all-purpose scheme is appropriate for the selection of study sites. The criteria used should vary in line with the theoretical questions being asked and the approach undertaken. It follows that we should be aware that general classifications of rural and urban (e.g. Webber and Craig, 1978; Coombes *et al.*, 1981; Cloke and Edwards, 1986) are of a limited value and are generally theoretically unprincipled (Warde, 1985).

Personal interest will dictate that some of us will want to work solely in rural locations. This is not to be decried. What is, however, is to extend this to ignore comparable social processes in urban centres and to search for explanations for what is happening in small settlements and the countryside as though these areas were a unitary entity.

Lastly, I should make it clear that this paper has not been written in the spirit of favouring one approach to research. Nothing has been said about detailed studies of single places, for instance, yet these can be impressive vehicles for deepening our knowledge and evaluating theoretical ideas. Likewise, no comments have been made about investigations which focus on the totality of rural places in a nation (probably using less intensive, perhaps statistical, methods). I believe that each of these can add to our understanding (in specific ways, certainly). What I also believe is that the points made above are equally applicable to such investigations. The study of one place needs to be located in the context of its causal processes and not with regard to its physical attributes. Similarly, at the national level it helps us little to identify similarities between rural and urban; what we should focus on is the contrast between locations which carry theoretically significant markers (between places dominated by competitive or monopoly employment sectors, between poor and rich local councils, between settlements experiencing social disintegration and social vitality). Theoretical sampling will get us much farther than geographical sampling.

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